

At AI’s epicenter, residents take on the tech

In Bay Area, people have conflicting views about whether it is helpful or harmful.

By QUEENIE WONG

San Francisco Bay Area residents, living in the beating heart of the artificial-intelligence boom, are just as conflicted about the technology as the rest of the country.

As OpenAI showed off its latest AI assistants in San Francisco last week, protesters outside — some dressed as killer robots — demanded it keep AI away from the military. Thirteen miles away in Oakland the following day, some senior citizens sat down with a group of students to address AI angst at a grassroots tech event.

Even as the clash between tech titans and anxious activists intensifies, the debate about AI is increasingly permeating community events, with the young and old grappling with the changes AI is bringing to their cities and the world.

Many are confused and want answers.

Oakland resident Assata Olugbala, 81, asked for help removing Google’s AI bot Gemini from her devices after it started offering help she hadn’t requested.

“I’ve never invited it into my space,” she said. “But it starts talking to me and answering questions.”

While debates about building AI that surpasses human intelligence, flashy new gadgets and AI spending tend to dominate tech events, tech talks at last week’s Oakland Tech Week often had a different vibe.

The citywide annual event aims to bring technology to everyday consumers and constituents, and AI was one of its biggest concerns.

The event, which ended Saturday, featured panels [See AI, A11]



JOSH EDELSON Associated Press



PAUL KURODA For The Times

PEOPLE protest last week at the OpenAI DevDay conference in San Francisco. In Oakland, Heven Adugna, 17, helps Diana Young, 82, learn to use a cellphone.

California diesel tops \$8, pushing truckers to brink

Fuel is 32% above U.S. average. Consumers are affected too as prices of goods rise.

By NILESH CHRISTOPHER

The economics of trucking are deteriorating fast — and it’s particularly bad in California.

Fresno-based Jagroop Singh Deol operates two gas-guzzling rigs. One hauls refrigerated produce from California to the Midwest and brings back pet food, meat and auto parts. He drives another truck himself that transports goods for Amazon.

At the start of the year, a full tank of gas cost \$1,000. Now, Deol pays more than \$1,600. His business is bearing the brunt of California’s record diesel costs, which are 32% above the national average.

“We’re not making money,” Deol said. “Trucking isn’t a stable business.”

In his two-decade career, Deol’s fortunes have ebbed and flowed. The 2008 recession reduced him from an owner to a driver, whereas the 2020 pandemic boom made him millions. Now, he is hunkering down again,

downsizing his fleet from five to two. He says he may have to leave the industry entirely if diesel prices keep rising.

The average price of a gallon of diesel in California reached \$8.35 this week, up more than 60% from a year ago, according to the American Automobile Assn. The national average was \$6.32.

Gas prices have been steadily rising all year, and truckers now pay \$3 more than the average price a year ago. The price increase trickles down to all goods sold across the economy.

President Trump’s policies have run roughshod over the trucking industry. Just as the industry began recovering from a multiyear freight slowdown, the administration began cracking down on immigrant drivers earlier this year, exacerbating the impact from the erratic tariff announcements.

The industry, which hauls 70% of all freight in America, has taken the biggest hit after the war with Iran sent fuel prices soaring.

To temporarily relieve price pressure, the Group of 7 wealthy nations on Oct. 2 agreed to release 100 million barrels of emergency oil reserves over the next four months.

[See Diesel, A11]

Dreaded Kelvin wave is arriving

The Kelvin wave bearing down on Southern California this week is not the kind that draws surfers.

You don’t see it crash on shore, and by itself, it’s probably not even noticeable. But it can have a profound effect, adding 6 to 12 inches to background sea levels, potentially for months.

This is a major concern when combined with other sources of sea level rise, and could exacerbate the woes of California coastal cities and property owners.

The “coastally trapped” aquatic pulse has been slithering up the coast for weeks, fascinating scientists and weather watchers as it marched across the equatorial Pacific before splitting upon hitting the coast of Peru.

El Niño-fueled surge in the ocean raises risk of coastal flooding and beach erosion in Southland

By Rong-Gong Lin II

“It is arriving now,” UC Agriculture and Natural Resources climate scientist Daniel Swain said in an interview.

Swain said there’s not a particular singular moment of arrival. It’s more like “a gradual increase, because the surge, or the bulge in the ocean height itself ... takes a while to build.”

Dillon Amaya, an assistant professor at North Carolina State University’s Department of Marine, Earth and Atmospheric Sciences, said last week that he expected the wave would arrive in San Diego in the middle to later part of this week, and in Los Angeles perhaps three days later.

“The Kelvin wave by itself will not cause flooding,” Amaya said. However, “if there [See Wave, A14]

Trump reportedly told FBI to go after protesters

Whistleblower alleges the unconstitutional order involved ICE actions in L.A. area.

By KEVIN RECTOR

A former FBI intelligence analyst has alleged that President Trump ordered the FBI to launch unconstitutional investigations into immigration enforcement protesters from the Los Angeles area, according to a whistleblower report made public this week by Sen. Alex Padilla (D-Calif.).

The analyst also contended that substantial FBI resources were diverted to such inquiries, and that she drew retaliation for questioning their legality.

The White House and the top federal prosecutor in Los Angeles both denied the allegations.

Jill Fields, a former supervisory intelligence analyst based in L.A., said in a letter addressed to Congress from her attorneys that she was told Trump had ordered FBI Director Kash Patel to launch the inquiries after seeing a social media video of protests against U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement and U.S. Customs and Border Protection operations in Alhambra in February 2025.

Fields said that an initial assessment “determined that the protesters’ actions — video recording, use of a megaphone, and verbal objection — were constitutionally protected under the First Amendment and never crossed the line into impeding arrest or being a threat,” but that she and others were nonetheless directed to open investigations.

She said that a supervisor — whose name was redacted in the released report — said the investigation was moving forward because “the President wants this investigation.”

Separately, Fields alleged that she was informed that then-acting Deputy Atty. Gen. Emil Bove — [See FBI, A7]



LISA BOONE Los Angeles Times

REAL ESTATE agents say it’s tough to pinpoint the price of reputation. Above, the Stahl House in 2023.

Fame is a burden for iconic homes on sale

By JACK FLEMMING

Some of Southern California’s homes are almost as famous as its celebrities.

There’s the Ennis House, Frank Lloyd Wright’s Mayan Revival-style concoction of textile blocks. The Chemosphere, John Lautner’s modernist UFO hovering above Hollywood Hills. And the Gamble House, the Craftsman mansion in Pasadena that got its starring role in “Back to the Future.”

But the L.A. area’s most iconic home is the Stahl House, Pierre Koenig’s Mid-century masterpiece that seems to float above the city. Julius Schulman’s black-and-white photo of two women conversing in the cantilevered living room has been declared “the most famous picture ever taken of Los Angeles.”

So when the Stahl House

surfaced for sale late last year, experts assumed there would be a line of buyers stretching all the way to Sunset Boulevard. But so far, a deal hasn’t closed.

The house hit the market for \$25 million. With no takers, the price tag was trimmed to \$20 million in April. Still nothing.

L.A.’s luxury market regularly sees sales of \$20 million or more, so where’s the demand for a piece of the city’s architectural history, albeit one much smaller than most homes in that price range? Real estate agents say that selling iconic homes with storied pasts is much harder than it seems.

The first tricky part is pricing. Typically, an agent looks at bedrooms, bathrooms, square footage and neighborhood comparisons. But how do you price reputation? Does appearing in the [See Homes, A14]

Water bills have ballooned

Californians pay some of the nation’s highest rates, one report says; utilities rebut findings.

By IAN JAMES

If you’ve noticed your water bills getting a lot more expensive, you’re not alone.

In a new nationwide survey of 500 large drinking water utilities, researchers found that average water bills have gone up 1.6 times as fast as inflation, and Californians are paying some of the highest bills.

The report by Food & Water Watch, a nonprofit advocacy group, shows that four water utilities in California rank among the 10 most expensive in the United States. The private utility San Jose Water Co. was No. 1, and others included Escondido, Santa Barbara and Marin Municipal Water District.

The researchers also found that more than half of the 25 most expensive water systems they looked at are in California. They include those in San José (11), San Francisco (14), Sacramento (15) and Oceanside (19), which the group said

charged bills totaling more than \$1,100 last year for typical indoor water usage for a household of three.

Los Angeles ranked 32nd of 500, with the annual water bill estimated at \$952.

“California is definitely overrepresented as one of the more expensive states,” said Mary Grant, the group’s water policy director. “Water affordability is a pressing issue for low-income households.”

Coastal cities in Southern California and the Bay Area tend to get their water from the aqueducts of the State Water Project or other [See Water, A7]



COLIN HUBBARD Associated Press

DODGERS ADVANCE TO NLCS



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